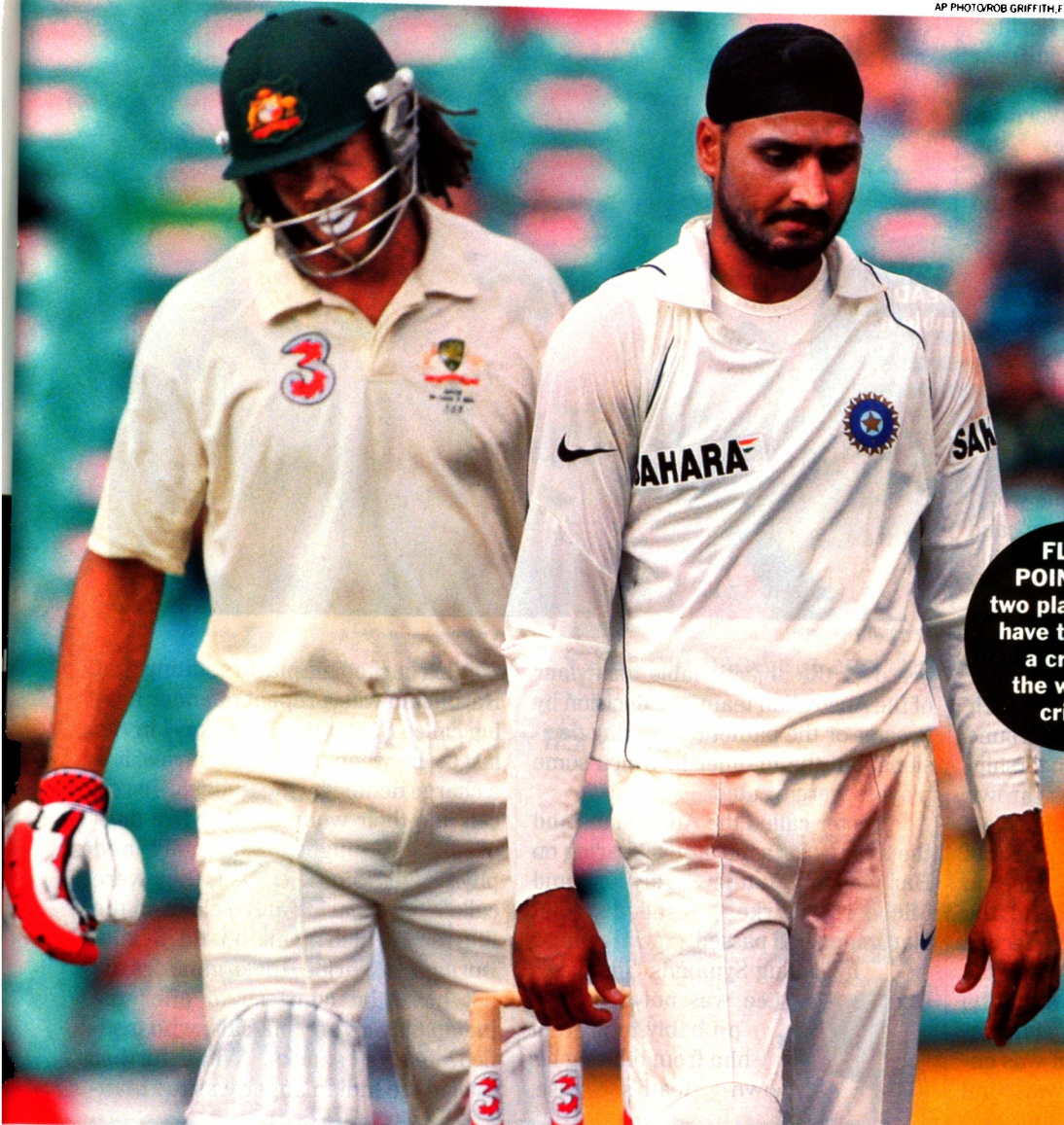




FLASH POINT: The two players who have triggered a crisis in the world of cricket

had been alerted by the events on the first day of the Test as the umpiring began to go pear shaped. The decision to remove Steve Bucknor was pragmatic, taken to spare the struggling veteran the scrutiny of television cameras and agitated commentators. It was also a choice between the continuation of the tour and its premature end. As a bilateral series, all gains and losses would have been India's and

Australia's alone, not ICC's.

"It was a simple question for us," an ICC official said privately. "Did we want a cricket crisis turning into a diplomatic row, or did we want cricket to go on. Mark Benson, the English umpire due to be replaced after Sydney in any case, left with little other than a hiding in the press while Bucknor had to suffer the ignominy of being replaced. The other controversial official, South African match referee Mike Procter, who imposed the three-match ban on Harbhajan and triggered the crisis, was joined by veteran peace broker Ranjan Madugalle of Sri Lanka for the

the racial slur against Harbhajan's name is struck off from the official records, the tour—and future relations—could still be in jeopardy.

This is what it has come to, even as Indian captain Anil Kumble sought to diffuse tensions with briefings in his impressive baritone, adding to his stature in the game with every passing day. Three days after cutting the Aussies to the quick by accusing them of not respecting the spirit of the game, he was joking about his team's beach volleyball stint on the Bondi beach. "I never thought we played such good beach volleyball. There were about 15 journalists to cover that." In comparison to the petulant-under-siege and unrepentant Ponting, Kumble has come out looking like a statesman and the rare adult in the fracas.

The Indians are adamant: unless Harbhajan's name is cleared of racial slurs, the tour is still in jeopardy.

The gap between the two Tests is being used as a breather for ICC to speak to the two boards, the boards to reach their players and ask them to rein themselves in to allow the rest of the tour to go on.

In the end the compromise that was worked out by ICC, cricket's governing body, and BCCI, was the best possible solution to stop the tour from being called off, leading to huge revenue losses for sponsors, advertisers and television broadcasters. ICC, it is learnt,

restoration of harmony and order.

It will be a tough task given the suspicion that has crept in between the camps. Playing in Australia has always been cricket's biggest test, because they play with skill and know-how to exert pressure on their opponent of choice. An international official said, "The Australians know how to bend the rules smartly; they won't abuse near the stump mikes, they exploit the situation perfectly. It's obvious they wanted to nail Harbhajan, they created the